Plan30003 - Research Methods for Planners | SM1, 2024

Assessment 4: FINAL REPORT

Bridging the Gap: Transforming Manningham's Bus Transport for Inclusive Mobility

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Introduction

The City of Manningham is located southeast of the Melbourne CBD, includes 12 suburbs, and covers approximately 113 square kilometres. Throughout personal experience of living in this municipality and its distinguishing feature of having only bus services as public transportation, issues have been discovered. The issues are associated with service inadequacy and, most importantly, inconvenience for the disadvantaged population. Simultaneously, the City of Manningham (2021) is envisioning being "an inclusive and safe community". However, a crucial gap exists in the Manningham bus service, affecting the mobility of the disadvantaged population. This paper examines the question of how Manningham can enhance its bus services to suit the activity patterns and accessibility needs and mitigate the barriers for its disadvantaged populations.

Research Methods

In addressing the gap of Manningham, qualitative data are being adopted; this paper primarily focuses on policy analysis by viewing government papers that relate to the bus service and inclusivity, and mapping analysis is also being incorporated. According to MacCallum et al. (2019, p.178, 179), analysing maps requires considering the characteristics that maps depict, such as what subgroups of the community population are showing as evidence to the research question. Therefore, secondary data from ABS and Profile ID are collected to identify the specific target population group distribution. Also, data from Victoria Data Share have been extracted and generated into ArcGIS mapping. MacCallum et al. mentioned that mapping data is about searching for meaningful patterns. Thus, the maps used in this paper are observed and compared to interpret the relationship between the local bus services and the accessibility of vulnerable populations.

Results: data analysis & findings

Table 1 shows a brief rating for the researched policy document analysis. This paper has researched eight policy documents and viewed the four aspects respectively. The four assessed aspects are vision, strategies, goals, and community engagement.

The policy data is being assessed by Manningham City Council (MCC) and the Victoria State Government. The City of Manningham has been assessed from different angles by its council plan, transportation strategy, and community plans, which focus on the research question.

The Council Plan (MCC, 2021) sets out five themes, including "Healthy Community" and "Liveable Places and Spaces", which define the council's vision of fostering an inclusive and safe community and, most importantly, the Healthy Community and Livable City. Meanwhile, the MCC also emphasises the plan of making the community "connected and inclusive" (p.19) and creating "well-connected, safe and accessible travel" (p.40) for the city structure.

Manningham has proposed many transportation policy plans. Two plans have been selected for this paper, which are Making Manningham Mobile (MMM) (MCC, 2009) and Transport Action Plan (MCC, 2021). These documents comprehensively outlined the city's strategic measures for the PT.

MMM is an earlier PT strategy document featuring broad objectives and action plans focusing on the local bus service. However, MMM emphasises the PT transition goals more but offers little information towards specific project plans. Therefore, it has been ranked high in vision (from Table 1) but lower in the other columns.

Additionally, the Transport Action Plan is a revision document of adopted information from MMM, including more, with a clear vision and strategies. It further highlights the prioritised places and details of ongoing projects. The strategy acknowledges the current transportation issues, such as poor bus service performance, high car dependency and the need for services friendly to ageing populations (p.1). The vision has addressed these issues and aims to develop a comprehensive transportation system integrated with a 20-minute neighbourhood strategy to foster an accessible PT service.

Furthermore, the community-related documents have been assessed, including the Child Safe Policy (MCC, 2019), Manningham's Health and Wellbeing Strategy (MCC, 2021), and Liveable City Strategy 2040 (2022). These policy documents commonly focus on the community's warfare and safety and outline actions to achieve the objectives.

The Child Safe Policy highlights enhancing public awareness of caring for and protecting children. At the same time, Manningham's Health and Wellbeing Strategy focuses more dynamic for the youth, disabilities, and ageing populations. It demonstrates different goals, Priority Areas, and action areas. However, these documents are less focused on public transport-related actions but manage to be inclusive towards the disadvantaged population. Conversely, the Liveable City Strategy establishes the plan of having "Sustainable Transport and Travel Mode Choice [to] contribute to liveability" (p.20).

Victoria's bus plan (Victoria State Government, 2023) is a broader state-scale bus plan; it includes the objectives towards bus performance and community satisfaction and concerns about the cost of bus construction. Whereas the 2023-2024 budget plan outlines the council's expenditure allocations, where $24 million is planned for Liveable Places and Spaces (p.3), and 3.64% of the cost on the age and disabilities support service (p.11).

The findings suggest that the policy with the highest scale in Table 1 is the Transport Action Plan. It has clear visions and detailed strategies that are more effective in addressing transportation challenges, which exemplifies its comprehensive measures. Conversely, although essential, policies that focus primarily on community welfare and cost, such as the Child Safe Policy and the 2023-2024 Budget, lack the specific strategies required to address transportation challenges directly.

Table 1: Policy analysis result (Adapted from Bush (2020)'s table)

Year	Policy	Sources	Key areas of focus	Vision (research question)	Strategies	Goals, targets	Engagement
2009	Making Manningham Mobile (MMM)	Ratio Consultants Pty Ltd (2009)	Transportation inclusivity, service delivery	***	**	*	0
2019	Child Safe Policy (2019)	Manningham City Council (2019).	Support wellbeing of children	*	*	*	*
2021	Manningham Transport Action Plan	Manningham City Council (2021)	Productive Bus Network & Service	***	***	***	**
2021	Manningham's Health and Wellbeing Strategy 2021-2025	Manningham City Council (2021).	Community welfare, inclusive city	**	*	*	**
2021	Manningham Council plan 2021-2025	Manningham City Council (2021).	Healthy community, liveable city	**	**	**	*
2022	Liveable City Strategy 2040	Manningham City Council (2022).	Liveability, 20 minutes neighbourhood	**	**	**	*
2023	2023/24 Budget	Manningham City Council (2023)	Healthy Community, liveable city	*	*	*	**
2023	Victoria's bus plan	Victoria State Government, Department of Transport (2023)	Better bus performance	**	**	**	**

0-Not stated.

*-Included but with little detail.

**-Included some detail.

***-Comprehensive coverage.

Discussion

The results section has analysed the policy documents, and in the discussion section, the triangulating method is adopted to analyse both policy research and the visual evidence from Profile ID maps to address the research question. The analysis helps to identify the gaps in PT service coverage, particularly for the disadvantaged groups and highlights the planning concern in Manningham.

Map Analysis

The map analysis revealed that Manningham's current bus stops do not adequately cover the entire municipality. Figure 2 demonstrates the walkability range of 800 metres, equivalent to the time of the "20-minute neighbourhood" concept outlined in the Liveability Strategy 2040 (MCC, 2022). According to Chau et al. (2022), walkable neighbourhoods support the creation of age-friendly, inclusive, and accessible environments. However, Figure 2 shows that the suburbs lack adequate bus stop services, including Wonga Park and Ringwood North.

Whereas Figure 1 highlights the distribution of disadvantaged populations, including children, seniors over 65, people with disabilities, and those with long-term health conditions. According to the Victorian Health Promotion Foundation (2009) study, the age for independent mobility travel to school is from 11.6 years. Therefore, ages between 12 and 17 years old have been selected in this data collection. By comparing Figures 1 and 2, it is evident that the disadvantaged populations are underserved by the current bus service, which is particularly inaccessible for the younger generation needing transportation to school.

Policy analysis

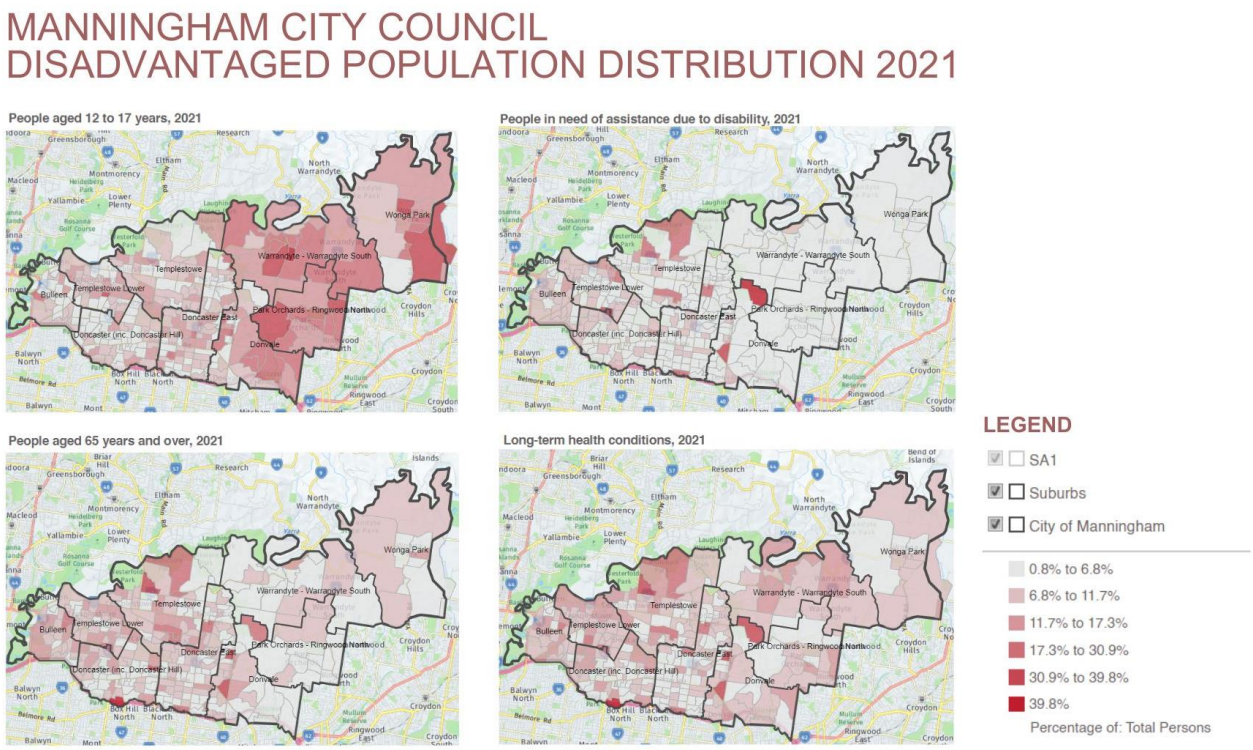
Furthermore, the policy analysis outlines the oversights in Manningham's policy documents that insufficiently address the transportation needs of disadvantaged populations. As shown in the Budget Plan, there are some budget allocations that support disability and ageing populations. However, none of these funds are mentioned for use in public transport services targeting these populations. Lin et al.'s (2021) article has strengthened the importance of setting policies and legislation that consider the mobility needs of vulnerable populations. Where effective policies should include the "availability, accessibility, and affordability" aspects of PT service, further focusing on "equity, comfort, convenience, health, independence, well-being, and social inclusion".

Nevertheless, the results of incorporating policy research and map analysis differ from the expectation of a walkable neighbourhood (Chau et al., 2022) or comprehensive policy frameworks targeting vulnerable populations (Lin et al.,2021). Both analysis methods have reflected the lack of bus service in Manningham. The result especially shows the lack of

community awareness among vulnerable groups who need additional help. Therefore, for Manningham's planning practice, the findings suggest that the MCC need to prioritise transportation inclusivity in the policy frameworks. Developing policies and transportation strategies that specifically address the mobility needs of disadvantaged populations will be crucial. To ensure equitable and accessible PT services for social inclusion.

Figure 1.

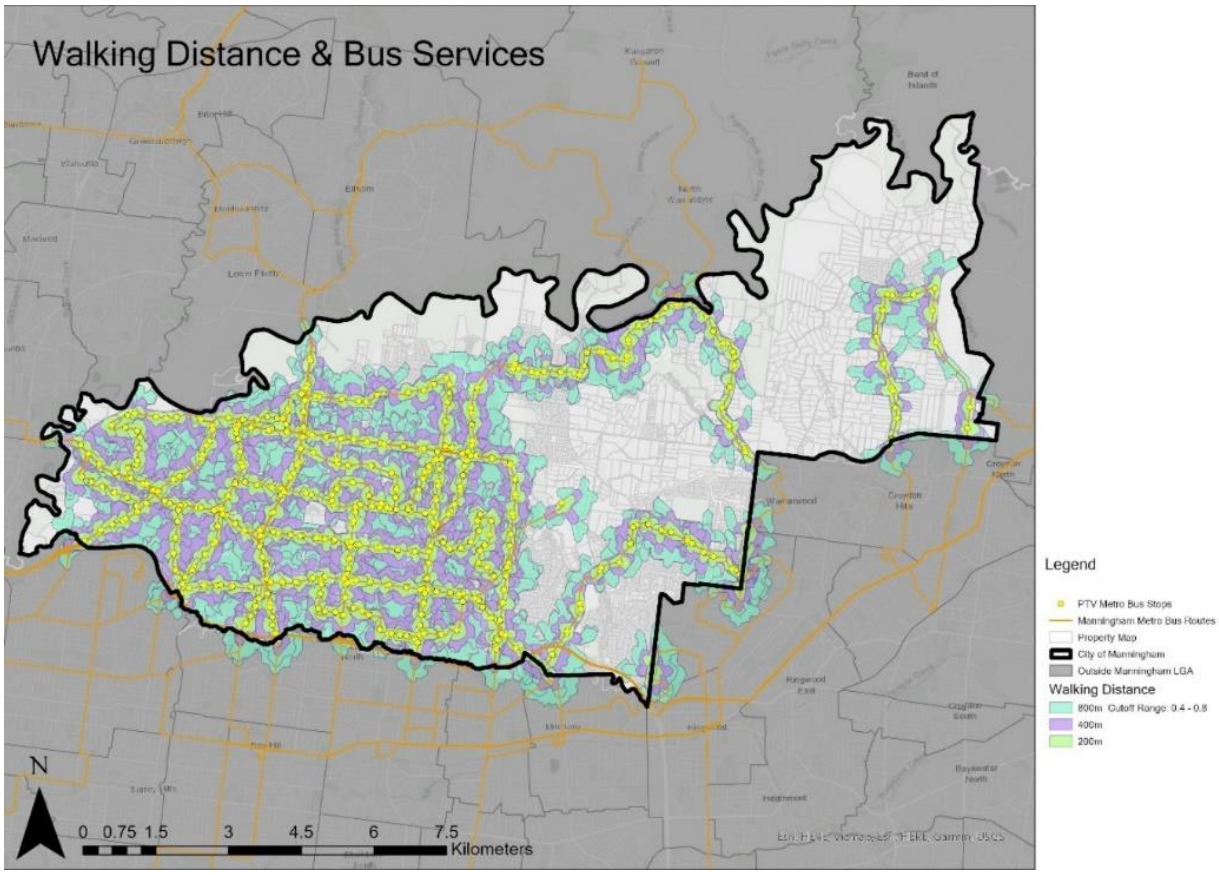
Manningham's Disadvantaged population distribution



Note. Adapted from *.id community demographic resources* Manningham City Council social atlas. https://atlas.id.com.au/manningham. Copyright @ 2021 .id community.

Figure 2.

Walking Distance & Bus Services in Manningham



Note. Walking Distance from the Bus Stops. Own work. Made by Jiayi Liu, 2024. Data extracted from Victoria Datashare https://datashare.maps.vic.gov.au/.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the research examined the question of what Manningham can do for disadvantaged populations facing barriers in accessing bus services through the primary analysis of policy research and supporting map analysis. Eight policy documents were assessed, highlighting the Manningham City Council's significant role in managing inclusive bus service provision. However, several limitations were identified, including a lack of policies and guidelines to assist vulnerable populations and a general lack of awareness about their needs. Existing literature suggests applying more legislation and considering a comprehensive aspect of PT services for disadvantaged populations to enhance inclusivity, develop a more equitable infrastructure, and adopt diverse public transport methods in the future. Ultimately, planning for the needs of seniors and other vulnerable populations is also planning for all resident's collective future.

Reference:

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Declaration

I acknowledge the use of Grammarly in helping me review my writing at the final stage of preparing my assignment.

I used the following features: correctness and clarity.

I used the following prompt: "Correctness of sentences."

I critically reviewed the feedback generated by Grammarly and based on this, revised the writing using my own words and expressions.